

A drawing of the Gudimallam linga, showing the deity's battle-axe front and side.

Whatever the dating, it seems that Gudimallam was not some local aberration or a one-off. Other early examples of priapic statuary[4] suggest that Lord Shiva may initially have been worshipped in parts of India as the essence of male virility and fertility, although today the linga is seen as an aniconic representation of Lord Shiva as an infinite pillar of fire and energy without top or bottom.[5] Gudimallam appears to show the second stage of evolution of this early phallic cult: the deity emerging from that same linga in human shape as a forest god, standing in a supremely self-confident – even arrogant – pose, legs astride, feet pressed down on the shoulders of a kneeling dwarf, who could be Apasmara purusha, representing ignorance and death, but equally a *yaksha* or guardian of nature. He cradles a battle-axe and with his right hand he grasps a small ram by its feet, a prey to be sacrificed. A dhoti is fastened to the god’s waist by a girdle but the sculptor has been at pains to emphasise the figure’s maleness.

Gudimallam is an exceptional work of art in its own right, but it also heralds the dawn of a newly energised and increasingly accessible religion, no longer confined to the priestly caste, and converging on two main manifestations, classical and romantic: the first in the form of Lord Shiva, the second in Lord Vishnu, with adherents increasingly throwing in their lot with one or the other. Lord Vishnu’s presence was initially much less evident south of the Narmada divide but he too begins to assume physical